

Cats

Tens of millions of pet cats are kept worldwide. Some of these are pedigrees – breeds “designed” with a special look, such as a striking coat pattern or long hair. Most people love cats just for their appealing personalities and independent ways.



EYES

A reflective layer in the eye helps a cat see well at night. This layer gleams green when light strikes it.



WHISKERS

The touch-sensitive whiskers help a cat to judge the width of gaps.



TONGUE

Tiny barbs on a cat's tongue give it a rough texture. This is useful for grooming and for licking meat from bones.

AGILE BODY

Cats are built for speed and agility. A bendy spine and loose-fitting skin allow them to twist and stretch in all directions. Powerful leg muscles enable them to run fast, leap high, and climb.

The tail provides balance when the cat jumps and climbs

Strong hindlegs give cats a powerful spring

Loose-fitting skin allows easy movement

The sharp claws retract (pull back) into a pocket in the foot when not needed

SHORT-HAIRED CATS

The first cats to be kept as pets, probably about 4,000 years ago, were short-haired. This type is the favourite with cat owners today. Colours and markings show up clearly on short hair and the coat is easy to groom.



CHARTREUX



KHAO MANEE



MUNCHKIN



SIAMESE

LONG-HAIRED CATS

These cats are shaggy, silky, or fluffy, depending on type. Some longhairs, such as the Persian, have an immensely thick underlayer to their coat that needs daily brushing and combing.



TURKISH VAN



SIBERIAN



NORWEGIAN FOREST CAT

TAIL LANGUAGE

A cat uses its tail to give out messages about its feelings. Learning to read this “language” helps us to understand cats.

A MOTHER CAT HOLDS HER TAIL UPRIGHT AS A SIGN TO HER KITTENS TO FOLLOW HER



PLEASED/EXCITED
Pointing straight up and quivering.



WATCHFUL
Twitching slightly from side to side.



READY TO ATTACK
Held bristling over the back.



ANXIOUS
Upright and fluffed out.

TRUE OR FALSE?

Cats are mysterious animals. It is not surprising that people wonder what to believe about them. These are some popular sayings.



CATS HAVE NINE LIVES
False. Cats are good at landing on their feet after a fall or getting out of trouble but they have only one life.



CATS SPEND MOST OF THEIR TIME SLEEPING
True. Even an active cat sleeps on average for about two-thirds of its day.



BLACK CATS BRING BAD LUCK
False. This is folklore that is repeated in many regions. Some people say black cats are lucky.



CATS CAN BE RIGHT-PAWED OR LEFT-PAWED
True. Female cats are more likely to use the right paw, while male cats tend to use the left.



CATS USE THEIR WHISKERS FOR BALANCE
False. Cats' whiskers are “feelers” for finding the way, not for balancing.

KITTENS

Born blind and helpless, kittens turn into cats in a very short time. At about 10 weeks old they no longer rely on their mother. They can wash themselves, climb, jump, and hunt pretend prey.



1 FOUR DAYS

Although its eyes are glued shut, the kitten can sense its surroundings.



2 TWO WEEKS

The eyes have opened, but the kitten cannot see very well.



3 FOUR WEEKS

Already toddling about, the kitten uses its tail for balance.



4 EIGHT WEEKS

Very active, the kitten is learning how to be a grown-up cat.



5 TEN WEEKS

The kitten is nearly independent and ready to leave its mother.